



seasons. "The rhythm has been there right from the first match this season. Playing many practice matches helped. Apart from playing a few matches at home, we have also travelled to compete in tournaments like the Buchi Babu Trophy. **Ranji Trophy doesn't feel like a step above after playing these games,"** the medium pacer had said in the earlier chat. This experience of playing on diverse pitches has helped him get accustomed to non-native surfaces more quickly. J&K won its final three knockout encounters away from home en route to lifting the Ranji Trophy title, with Nabi picking up a five-wicket haul in each game.

Nabi's tally of 60 wickets in 2025/26 is the third-most by a pacer in the premier domestic tournament's history, behind Jaydev Unadkat's 67 (2019/20) and Dodda Ganesh's 62 (1998/99). Ganesh did not add to his four Test caps despite

a dominant season, but believes Nabi deserves a place in the Indian team. "[Nabi showed] bowlers are also capable of winning you titles. He has shown his character. He deserves to play for India. When a player gives performances like this, they should play for the country. He can bat too. He is a good prospect," the former Karnataka pacer said.

There has been enough evidence through the recently concluded season to suggest that Nabi is ready to perform under pressure. He also displayed his ability with the willow during a Vijay Hazare Trophy encounter against Hyderabad, scoring a scintillating hundred coming in at number eight to take his side past the finish line.

With Afghanistan playing a one-off Test against India in New Chandigarh in June, there is an opportunity to reward Nabi's domestic performances with a Test

Dual threat: With the ability to move the ball both ways, Nabi was always going to be a menace to batters in the domestic circuit with the new red cherry in hand. But the real differentiator has been his ability to hit the right lengths with the old ball too, denying batters the chance to tilt the game back in their favour.

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cap. The tour of Sri Lanka later in the year, where pitches have traditionally favoured tweekers, could also open the door for the inclusion of a pacer who can bat. If the selectors are convinced, he might even find himself on the plane to England for the white-ball tour. With the medium pacer at the peak of his powers after a stellar campaign, the time appears ripe for the selectors to give him a chance in the unyielding cauldron of international cricket.